

Strengthening Community Relationships for Effective Cancer Prevention and Screening: A Health Promotion Community Engagement Pilot

POSTER CATEGORY

Population Health
and Health Services

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Our Goals

- Establish trusting relationships with communities in British Columbia to support effective public health education on cancer prevention and screening.
- Engage local advocates, including community leaders, cross-cultural health promoters, and health professionals, to enhance accessibility to screening services.
- Address equity challenges by implementing targeted community activities, presentations, and workshops, optimizing the impact of BC Cancer's outreach initiatives.

Background

Market research indicates that 92% of BC residents are interested in cancer prevention and screening, with over 40% being "very interested"¹. There is strong interest in topics such as nutrition, physical activity, air pollution, and sun safety.

Significant knowledge gaps, especially among young women and older adults, point to the need for targeted outreach. In-person community engagement help bridge these gaps by providing tailored information and fostering connection through shared experiences².

In January 2024, BC Cancer's Prevention, Screening, and Hereditary Cancer Program launched a community-level health promotion pilot to increase awareness and engagement in cancer screening services and prevention across British Columbia.

Methods

Focus on population health

- The community engagement pilot offers in-person events to share information on provincial screening programs (breast, cervix, colon, and lung) and prevention strategies addressing cancer risk factors such as sun safety, physical activity, tobacco, alcohol, and nutrition.

Participation and empowerment

- Events, including booths, presentations, and workshops, are supported by health promotion staff, co-op students, and partnered non-profit organizations, extending BC Cancer's reach.
- New promotional items, including vegetable seed kits, fruit-shaped stress balls, and an interactive trivia wheel with evidence-based myth-busting questions on cancer prevention and screening, encourage positive health behaviors.

Context adaptation

- Accessible print, digital, and video materials in multiple languages increase inclusivity, with some events supported by volunteer translators.
- Culturally-safe, trauma-informed resources, familiar venues, and trusted health promoters strengthen engagement.

Results

In its first eight months, the pilot has facilitated over **5,000 meaningful interactions** with individuals interested in cancer prevention and screening through implementation of community engagement booths set up at more than **75 unique venues and events** such as shopping malls, health conferences, farmers' markets, community centres, and more.

Case Study: REACH Breast and Cervix Screening Workshops

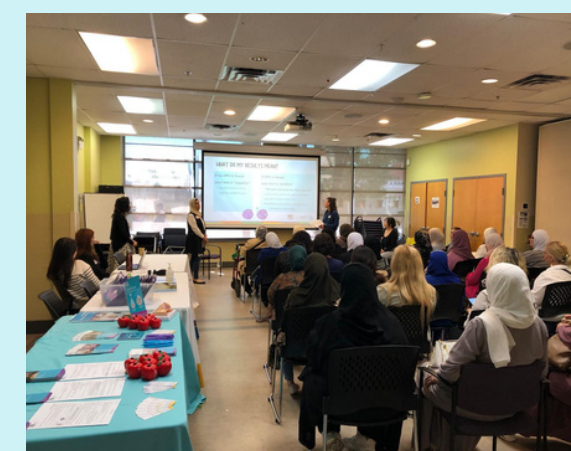
A key effort of the pilot was the collaboration with REACH Community Health Centre to conduct culturally-safe workshops focused on cervical and breast screenings, and featuring the new HPV cervix self-screening kits. These workshops provided resources and built capacity for four communities facing access barriers, empowering women from Arabic-speaking, Indigenous, Spanish-speaking, and Vietnamese backgrounds. Reaching over 160 participants, the workshops encouraged discussions about cancer screening within their families, friends, and communities.

4
screening
workshops

160+
women
reached

54
cervix self-screening
kits distributed

12
screening mammograms
booked



Conclusion

Through ongoing community engagement, BC Cancer's Prevention, Screening, and Hereditary Cancer Program aims to support public health by reaching rural, Indigenous, newcomer, and other equity-deserving communities with prevention and screening initiatives. We hope to ultimately enhance public understanding of cancer risks and prevention strategies, and increase uptake of available screening programs across the province.

References

1. Mustel Group. (2023, August). Community Outreach Survey.
2. Bader, B., Coenen, M., Hummel, J., Schoenweger, P., Voss, S., & Jung-Sievers, C. (2023). Evaluation of community-based health promotion interventions in children and adolescents in high-income countries: a scoping review on strategies and methods used. BMC Public Health, 23(1), 845.